Fire Reimagined

How fire changes for Montag in *Fahrenheit 451*

Claim: By the end of Part III, Montag goes from burning books to saving them. Fire goes from something that destroys to something that brings people together.

Theme: What matters is not the tools you use but what you use them for. People can change.

At the Start

"It was a pleasure to burn" (Bradbury 1).

Montag likes burning books and doesn't think about it.

Burning His House

"He burnt the bedroom walls and the cosmetics chest because he wanted to change everything" (Bradbury 113).

He is burning away his old life with Mildred. The fire feels like a fresh start.

Killing Beatty

"...all writhing flame on the lawn as Montag shot one continuous pulse of liquid fire on him" (Bradbury 119).

Montag fights back against authority, but with violence. He has changed, but not in a good way yet.

The River

"He was moving from an unreality that was frightening into a reality that was unreal because it was new" (Bradbury 141).

Water is the opposite of fire. The river is like a fresh start, and Montag leaves his old life behind.

The Campfire

"It was not burning. It was warming" (Bradbury 145).

For the first time, fire is a good thing. It brings people together instead of destroying things.

The Ending

"A time to break down, and a time to build up" (Bradbury 165).

The city is destroyed, but Montag remembers part of the Bible and wants to help rebuild, like the phoenix.

The Cost of Awakening

What he loses: his house, his wife, his job, and his old identity. He also kills Beatty, and in the end his whole city is bombed.

Why it can't be avoided: In Montag's society, you can't think for yourself and keep a normal life. Like the phoenix, he has to lose everything before he can start over. Bradbury shows that knowing the truth is worth more than being comfortable.